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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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CHAPTER X TROUBLE OVER A MARRIAGE OF ALMS

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One evening when I had been with Malam Maigari for about seven years, we women were sitting eating our evening meal when we heard someone at the entrance, 'Peace be upon you!' Our husband's elder brother said 'Ap. Who's that?' He called out 'Upon you be peace!' and he went out to the entrance. He saw Dankiawa's younger brother, Audu and Dankiawa's wife Tsohuwa and daughter Uwa, whose head and face were covered, they were there at the door of our compound. I said 'What, have they brought us a bride of alms?' and everyone laughed. Uwa's mother had said one day to Malam that he must build a two-storeyed room like the ones the Arabs build, (¹⁷⁵) and she would give him a bride as a gift. But he was certain she would not be able to do it, because the girl's father did not agree, so when he had built the new hut I went into it and left my old hut. Uwa was my *kawa*. Then, when they had come to the entrance, Audu the younger brother of Uwa's father said to Sule 'Give her to Malam Maigari as alms'. Sule took her hand and gave her to me, I took her hand and led her to my hut—we were delighted. Then Sule went and told Malam, he came out and he was glad indeed. Then Audu and Tsohuwa went home.

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We tidied the hut, we put on our best things, then we played and drummed on calabashes and celebrated. Uwa's father knew nothing about all this; his

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younger brother Audu had held the ceremony for her marriage to one of the Prophet's representatives that morning, and brought her over with her mother at night. Their compound was next but one to ours, so when her father Dankiawa heard our drumming he asked in his squeaky voice, 'What is the meaning of all that drumming?' Tsohuwa, Uwa's mother's co-wife said 'There is a marriage in Danbailu's house, they have married Maigari and Uwa'. He said nothing and returned to his  152 hut. He was angry. Before this he had married her off to his brother (in the household of his brother?) in Beli, she was taken there and when she had been there for three months she ran away; after they took her back she ran away again. Her mother didn't approve of the marriage but her father wished to marry her to his kinsman. Finally she broke it off, she went away into Kano country and got a divorce. When she came back she and her own mother, Giwa, put their heads together. Tsohuwa was Giwa's co-wife. Uwa wanted Maigari and he wanted Uwa very much indeed. Very well, Giwa consulted with her husband's younger brother Audu, she coaxed him, she persuaded her joking relation, they talked the matter over until he agreed. So they brought Uwa to our compound as a bride of alms. (¹⁷⁶) Next morning we sent twenty thousand cowries as a gift to the bringers of alms. Her father was hot with anger, he said to his wife Giwa 'Pick up your belongings and clear out!' She replied 'Very well', she departed and went to live in her son's compound; she paid her money and had a hut built for herself in the forecourt of his compound and there she lived, she never remarried. Dankiawa drove away her children too, he didn't want them, he didn't like them at all after that. They went to live with their mother and her kin.

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'Of the South Gate'—i.e. 'One born at the South Gate', name-avoidance between a woman and her eldest child. It is an index of the gravity of Musa's behaviour that his mother should speak to him about it directly instead of getting another relative to do so.

Presumably Baba's treatment was intended to cause the child to pass all the 'pregnant milk' out of his system. The bull is symbolic of strength and sexual vigour.

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